1970 in the face of vociferous objections from environmentalists, who thought the rock was best left untouched, and from the local Christian community, who declared the islet to be St Xavier's Rock.

But it is what was built on the second island that draws all eyes. It was entirely funded by the state government of Tamil Nadu, took ten years to construct and was completed in the last days of 1999. It takes the form of a 133-feet-high statue in granite of a standing human male figure. He is thickly bearded, formidable in appearance and faces inland, his right hand raised in the three-fingered salute familiar to every Boy Scout. What is so unusual about this statue in the Indian context is that it represents neither a deity, nor a ruler, nor a recently deceased politician. The statue is of the Tamil moral philosopher and poet Thiruvalluvar, and each of its 133 feet is said to represent a chapter of his literary masterpiece: the two-thousand-year-old *Thirukkural*, or 'Revered couplets'. His three raised fingers signify the three major themes expounded in that writing: *Aram*, *Porul* and *Inbam* – respectively, 'morals', 'public ethics' and 'love'.

Cynics who read Thiruvalluvar's *Thirukkural* in translation might be inclined to dismiss it as a collection of platitudes delivered in rhyming couplets. The poet has also been criticised for his patriarchal view of women, and even that great champion of Tamil culture Robert Caldwell felt able to satirise his verse in a spoof poem he wrote in his *Chutney Lyrics*, published anonymously in 1871, which begins:

> *Cursed is the man, whatever his worth,*
> *Who is poor in purse and low in birth.*
>
> *The unity of the Tamilian nation*
> *Is cemented by caste and litigation.*
>
> *To cook for man, woman was chiefly meant.*
> *Ignorance is her best ornament.*